the natural sciences led to detailed descriptions of Indian society in the eleventh century. [37]

After Muhammad Ghori's death, Qutb ud-Din Aibak declared independence and established himself in Delhi and Lahore. Having successfully resisted rival forces before his death, he was succeeded by the head of his bodyguard, a slave named Shamsuddin Iltutmish (whose coinage, incidentally, featured a Sanskritized version of his name: Suratana Sri Samsadina). [38] This period witnessed an aborted invasion of India in 1222 by Genghis Khan, whose forces stopped at Multan, unable to deal with the heat and damp of India. [39] In 1229, just a few years before the sack of Baghdad by the Mongols devastated the institution of the Caliphate, Iltutmish received a deed of investiture (*manshur*) from the Caliph that recognized his autonomy as a Sultan. The Delhi Sultanate—led by a succession of dynasties including the Khiljis, Tughlaqs, Sayyids, and Lodis—witnessed a variety of international exchanges. [40] This included the visit of the famed Morocco-born traveller Ibn Battuta, who spent considerable time in India, with detours to the Maldives and Sri Lanka, before travelling on to China. The invasion and sacking of Delhi by Timur in 1398–99—which included the capture of stone masons to build monuments in Samarkand—left the Sultanate weakened and strengthened the claims of later arrivals from Central Asia. [41]

A major transition occurred with the establishment of the Mughal dynasty following the invasion of Babur. Babur was an heir to Ferghana in present-day Uzbekistan, but after suffering military setbacks in Central Asia, he managed to establish himself as a ruler in Kabul. Fifteen years later, he began conducting a series of invasions against India culminating in a decisive battle at Panipat in 1525, where his cavalry and canons were used to great effect against Ibrahim Lodi's elephants and mercenaries. Under Babur's grandson Akbar, the Mughal Empire extended its rule to Kashmir and Balochistan and subjugated the rebellious Afghan tribes. But after the death of Akbar's great-grandson Aurangzeb, the Empire experienced a decline, a combination of succession crises, Maratha ascendancy, financial overextension, and secessionism, especially after 1720. [42]